

Evolution

Fossils of prehistoric animals show us that life on Earth is always changing. Over time, old species disappear and new ones develop from them, like new relatives appearing in a family tree. These new species appear thanks to a process of gradual change we call evolution.

NATURAL SELECTION

Evolution is driven by a process called natural selection. Animals and plants produce more offspring than survive to adulthood, all of them slightly different. Nature selects those with the best characteristics, which then pass on these characteristics to the next generation.

The giraffe's neck

The giraffe's long neck evolved because natural selection weeded out individuals that couldn't reach food high in the trees. With each generation, the tallest giraffes got the most food and had the most babies. Over time, the species changed as its neck grew longer.

▲ BREEDING FROGS lay many hundreds of eggs, but only a tiny number will survive to become adults themselves.



TAKE A LOOK—A STORY OF FINCHES

The most famous person to collect evidence for the idea of evolution was the English naturalist Charles Darwin. He visited the Galápagos Islands in the 1830s, where he found a range of similar finch species, each with a beak suited to its particular diet. He realized they'd all evolved from a common ancestor that had settled on the islands long ago.



Woodpecker finch
Camarhynchus pallidus



Medium ground finch
Geospiza fortis



Vegetarian finch
Platyspiza crassirostris



Warbler finch
Certhidea olivacea